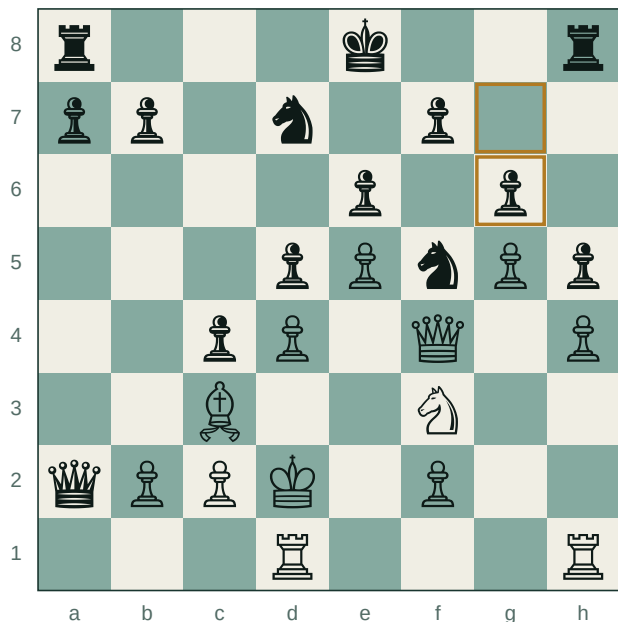


Trapping a piece: White, move 20

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 19...g6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20. Ra1 Qxa1 21. Rxa1

20.Ra1 The rook moves from d1 to a1. Recorded reply: **20...Qxa1**.

21.Rxa1 The rook captures the queen on a1.

At the end, nominal material is White 27 / Black 24 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +4: the balance goes from -1 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on e8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8 and rook on a8. Check for tactical protection.